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Lead Facilitator mute all: *51	Lead Facilitator unmute all: *53	Individuals unmute: *6

KF Introduction to NHG

Chapter 2: *Claims*¹

This book study is an essential foundation for your training in Karis Fellowships, but since Dr. Horney's work is just a theory to most of you right now, you might be asking yourself, "Can I rely on theories for personal guidance?" You might also be wondering who Nancy is. So, in the next two chapter introductions, Nancy would like to tell you a little about herself and explain how these theories have been proven through her own Christian life and work. She hopes that the evidence of her experience will encourage you as you begin the adventure of applying Horney's discoveries to your own life.

Nancy has been an active evangelical Christian for well over 50 years and has worked in churches, on the mission field in France, and in military chapels. Unfortunately, for many years, her idea of ministry was to make people conform to her own standards and theology. Ministry was the great cause to which she sacrificed her personal development and, often, the development of others. When Nancy was in her twenties, her health deteriorated, and she began to see her inadequacies. She realized that despite her efforts to be a good Christian, she was messed up. She understood from the Bible that God's love was to be the chief characteristic of every Christian life, but she found herself simply adhering to the rules of her training and upbringing. She was full of anxiety and reactive, manipulative judgments and knew that in her heart she could not love herself or others as Jesus loves. She imagined that she was a patient person, but in moments of self-awareness she knew that she was just *doing* patience. Have you ever experienced a person *doing* patience at you? Their eyes roll a little, their mouth compresses, they sigh, and only then do they say or do something conventionally patient. They are simply doing what they think a good person or Christian *should* do. This manufactured patience does not flow naturally from a connection to God's character; it is forced and comes across as judging and hypocritical rather than loving and safe.

We will hear more about Nancy's journey later when we talk about the "should", but right now let's look at claims. We have a claim when we feel entitled to have others and the world around us support our search for glory and accommodate our efforts to actualize the idealized self. Our self-confidence and trust in God are so stunted that we must use claims to maintain our pride and avoid the evidence that we are limited and imperfect creatures living in the material world of cause and effect. The less confidence we have in our ability to achieve neurotic glory, the more we will need our environment and community to support the illusions we have about ourselves. Furthermore, the less grounded we are in our real self, the more intense our reactions will be to life's impositions. If life, others, and God do not offer us what we believe we have a right to or deserve, our basic anxiety is triggered, and we feel deeply insecure. We perceive life and others as hostile, out of our control, and unfair. Our neurotic response is to insist that our claims are indulged. These claims are most easily imposed on those who are under our care, as they will often readily comply with our demands simply to avoid the smack of our indignation.

One of the benefits of training our real self, the self that God created, is that we feel less anxious, and because we are less anxious, we are more able to authentically extend ourselves for the purpose of nurturing our own growth and the growth of others. When our real self is connected to God, we

¹ Karen Horney, *Neurosis and Human Growth* (New York: Norton, 1991).

experience a continual flow of genuine gratitude. Everything that comes to us becomes a gift, or *karis*. We are grateful for whatever is presented to us because we no longer need certain outcomes in order to feel safe. We don't demand that life and others support our pride because we no longer need our pride. Whatever comes into our lives becomes an opportunity to grow our trust in God, and every effort that we make toward relationship, toward learning and building, becomes an offering to Him. Energy that we habitually wasted in managing anxiety can now be used for constructive moves. We can give thanks without ceasing, exchange our fears for wonder, love without restraint, and develop an expanding appreciation of truth. We can become the people God intended us to be.

KF Facilitator Guide

Chapter 2: *Neurotic Claims*¹

0:00 Weekly/1:00 Weekend Intensive (WI).

Lead Facilitator starts the recording by pressing *9.

“Welcome everyone to chapter 2 of *Neurosis and Human Growth*. We will begin our study by reading Nancy’s introduction to the chapter.”

Support Facilitator reads the Introduction above.

Lead Facilitator: “Thank you. Let’s go to Presenting. Please remain muted until you are ready to talk. When you give us your name and location, you might also share something that you are thankful for. I will begin.”

“My name is _____ and I am calling from _____. I am thankful for _____.”

- Facilitators open the [NHG Spreadsheet](#) to record attendance and homework completion.
- Each facilitator makes a list of the names of students as they present.
- Lead facilitator prepares group divisions while students present.
- Lead facilitator assigns groups and says, “To leave the main group, press *3 and then, when prompted, enter your group number. To return to the main group, press *3*.”
- Each facilitator asks, “Is there anyone who has not filled out their reading guide?”
- Each facilitator assigns the first 10 questions to two students, 5 questions each. Continue to answer the questions in sets of 10, assigning 5 questions per student in rotation.

Open questions 11, 16, 21, and 29 to the whole group, and there are no correct answers.

0:20/1:10 WI

1. In what two worlds do neurotics live? (40.1)

- A. **The secret private life**
- B. **The official life—the life they present to the world**

2. Is the neurotic consciously aware of living in two worlds? (40.1)

No.

3. What do neurotics conclude about the world? (41.1)

They conclude that there is something wrong with it. It ought to be different.

Instead of tackling their illusions, neurotics present a claim to the outside world. This claim is part of their legal system and is a judgment about how life should treat them. They feel entitled to be treated by others or life events in accordance with their grandiose opinion of themselves. Everyone and everything ought to cater to neurotics and their illusions. Anything short of this is “unfair”. They are always entitled to a better deal.

4. To what kinds of things do neurotics feel entitled? (41.2)

Special attention, consideration, deference on the part of others, and exemption from the adverse

consequences of their choices.

Neurotics believe that all their needs ought to be satisfied and duly respected, including those that stem from their inhibitions, fears, and conflicts. Whatever they feel, think, or do ought not to carry adverse consequences. They should not need to change themselves in order to solve their difficulties. It's their difficulties that should magically and effortlessly be resolved.

5. Neurotics will not do something about their problems but expect others to do what? (41.2)

To see that they do not bother them.

6. When does a wish turn into a claim? (42.2)

When we feel that we are entitled to its fulfillment.

Claims are part of what Nancy calls a legal system. We develop laws that we believe others or life should follow. If others do not follow our laws, we feel wrath. Some of us do not allow ourselves to feel wrath; instead, we divert the energy into despondency, depression, anxiety, or hysteria. Some people will just shut down and think that they really don't care, but they often carry a smoldering resentment.

One student described the reaction to unmet claims like this: "Some people shut down. Some people withdraw. Some people get rabies."

7. As neurotics, what do we feel when claims are not fulfilled? (42.2)

We feel that the non-fulfilment is an unfair frustration and an offense about which we have the right to feel indignant.

We become of Righteous Judge of all the Earth determining what should and shouldn't happen. If God and the Creation do not cooperate, we become self-appointed judges of good and evil and act upon the wrath we feel.

We might use Bible verses to justify our wrath and prove that our judgments are supported by God.

8. Are neurotics willing to see the difference between a need and a claim? (42.3)

No, they are averse to seeing the difference.

Neurotics believe that their claims are understandable or natural wishes.

Examples:

- A woman wants friends and believes that she deserves friends, but she isn't willing to learn the skill of being a friend. She feels that it is unfair that others have friends.
- A man wants a job, but in his mind he shouldn't have to do anything about getting one. God should bring a job to him because he is exceptional.
- Someone wants to be healthy but thinks they should have inherited health. They shouldn't have to do what it takes to be healthy.

9. In general, to what do neurotics feel entitled? (42.4)

To everything that is important to them, to the fulfillment of all their particular neurotic needs.

There is a distinction between neurotic needs and real needs. Sometimes real needs are blown out of proportion and become neurotic needs. Sometimes neurotic needs have nothing to do with real needs.

The neurotic excuses himself from practical realities because his virtuous actions make him feel entitled to special treatment. Examples:

- I am so nurturing that I should not be held accountable for not telling the truth or for not keeping my word.
- I am above time and cause and effect. My ideals are so lofty that I shouldn't be bothered with time or financial responsibilities.
- I shouldn't have to work hard for things I want. Things should just come to me.
- I am entitled to an audience that is patient and accepts me unconditionally.

10. Toward what are neurotic claims directed? (43.1)

Human relationships, man-made institutions, life itself.

And toward God.

0:25/1:15 WI

11. In what situations have you experienced the claims mentioned in the book or any other claims? (43.4–44.1)

“This question is open to the whole group. Would anyone like to share their answers?”

- Others should never doubt, criticize, or question me
- I can get around my problems without having to tackle them and solve them myself
- I deserve exclusive, unconditional devotion
- I have a right to never be bothered
- I'm a special case and deserve special care and consideration
- Others, family, the government, and the church should take care of me
- My children should not get sick, and they should not bother me
- I have a right to a perfect marriage and a fully mature and healthy husband
- There should be no bugs or mice in MY house

It is natural to have needs, but when we feel like we DESERVE or are ENTITLED to having those needs met, they become claims.

12. What two claims did the author recognize when she was put off her flight? (44.4)

- To be an exception**
- To be taken special care of by providence**

She had to make up a story to justify her sense of entitlement when she didn't get her way. Nancy calls these “virtue stories”. These stories restore our pride when things don't go our way or when we want to excuse our choices.

13. When neurotics claim to be an exception, they want to be exempt from what? (44.5–45.2)

To be exempt from cause and effect, man-made rules, natural laws (psychic or physical), and social and relational rules of engagement.

He also wants to be exempt from spiritual and energetic laws. In reality, however, nobody gets away with anything. Let's stop deceiving ourselves into thinking that we can keep making poor choices and then expect healthy outcomes.

Psychic laws are inner constructs that help us function as integrated beings.

In chapter 4:8-9 of his letter to the Philippians, Paul teaches us about psychic laws:

“In all of your dealings take into account what is true, what is divinely noble, what is oriented and just, what is undefiled and pure, what is beloved, what imparts good omen. Notice if anything is excellent and commendable. ⁹And make it your business to practice these things.”²

It is a psychic law that if your mind does not dwell in what is true, noble, oriented, fair, undefiled, pure, beloved, positive, excellent, and commendable, you will not be able to live without severe inner conflict, especially if you are a Christian.

14. Neurotics have an intense, unconscious aversion to what? (45.3)

They are averse to the realization that they are subject to necessities, rules, and restrictions.

A therapist correctly observed that her client was averse to doing anything that he needed to do, but she could not explain that his aversion was related to his neurotic claims. The therapist had not read NHG!

A NHG student said, “My real self doesn’t want to do the dishes.” Actually, it is her neurotic self that hates the necessity of washing dishes.

15. Why are neurotics averse to the recognition of any necessities applying to themselves? (45.3)

It would pull them down from their lofty world into actuality, where they would be subject to natural laws like everyone else. In their private world everything should be possible.

Jesus points out our aversion to recognizing necessities in our lives and our efforts to imagine them away. He asks, “Can any man change his hair from white to black by anxiety?” (Matthew 5:36). Jesus Himself was tempted by Satan to bypass the natural laws of necessities, rules, and restrictions by turning stones into bread, jumping off temples, and acquiring kingdoms without effort.

0:30/1:20 WI

16. Give one or more examples from your own life of a claim toward life in general. (46.1-3)

Open this question to the group.

- A right to be happily married, to be loved, to not suffer, to be understood, to be affluent and successful, to be safe
- Life should go well if I do the right things
- My life should feel important all the time
- There should never be a time when things are not exciting or fun
- I should not be oppressed or ruled over
- I should live free from humiliation and shame

17. What appears as resentful envy toward others? (47.1)

The claim that “I should not be I”.

Horney’s example: A client thinks she should not have any problems at all. She is entitled to the combined excellencies of others that she observes. Her claim is that the analyst should supply her with desirable, and often contradictory, perfections. People sometimes direct this claim toward KF.

18. Neurotics want to be relieved of their difficulties without having to do what? (47.2)

They feel entitled to be relieved of their difficulties without having to go through the laborious process of changing.

Laborious change is very difficult and surprising. One student said: “I used to think that laborious meant that I could plan to resolve my neurosis in 6 weeks, but it might actually take 6 months! I had no idea that it would take effort for the rest of my life, like soul or body care.”

19. In what two regards are claims unrealistic? (47.4–48.2)

- A. **We establish a title (an entitlement) which exists in our mind only.**
- B. **We have little consideration for the possibility of the claim being fulfilled.**

Examples of unrealistic claims:

- My wife, child, or friend should be what I want them to be. They aren’t even trying!
- I have such great ideas that everyone should listen to me. I can see myself speaking to thousands in an arena. No one listens to me now, but if they would only listen, they would know how valuable I am.
- I need this addictive behavior—substances, sex, food, or gambling—and therefore I should not suffer any adverse consequences. I can still be spiritually healthy, lead others, and set a fine Christian example.

0:35/1:25 WI

20. What is a third characteristic of a claim? (49.2)

The expectation that things should come to us without our making adequate efforts.

We should not even have to be clear in our own minds about what we want nor take the trouble to ask for what we want. We should only be in the position to refuse or accept what is offered.

21. Which of the claims described do you recognize in yourself or others? What other claims might be active in your life? (48.2–51.1)

Open this question to the group.

- I have a right to be accepted just as I am
- The NHG study will automatically lead me to self-realization
- I am entitled to all the good things in life, including contentment
- Others are responsible for my welfare and happiness
- My problem is the world’s fault, and the world is responsible for fixing it
- It’s the job of the counselor/government/church/parent/KF to make me different

22. What is the fourth characteristic of claims? (51.2)

They are vindictive in nature. The person may feel wronged and insist on retribution.

The fulfillment of claims is felt as triumph and the frustration of claims is experienced as defeat.

Examples of vindictive behavior:

- Punishing others for not meeting our claims
- Exaggerating our experience, importance, and value
- Making others feel guilty and stupid
- Putting others down or extracting something from others
- Withholding, punishing, arguing, demanding

23. Are neurotics conscious of their claims? (51.3)

In most instances they are unconscious of their claims.

As neurotics, we use energy and our imagination to make life seem what we need it to be. Our energy is then not available for creatively managing life as it is.

24. What enables neurotics to view their lives in general as they need to see them? (51.4)

Their imagination.

Their view of themselves and their world is determined by their imagination. Because they imagine that the world is as they need it to be, there is no room in their mind for seeing that they have any needs or claims.

By focusing on what we imagine we should get from life, we actually miss all that it could be and the gifts that God has waiting for us.

25. Why do neurotics exaggerate their merits? (53.1)

They exaggerate their merits so that they can feel righteously abused if the services to which they feel entitled on the grounds of merit are not forthcoming.

We may unconsciously show kindness to another person to justify our claims on them. We then exaggerate the value or quality of our kindness in order to strengthen our claim in our own mind.

26. How do people use culture to support claims? (53.2)

People think they are entitled to certain partialities based on the cultural grounds, such as gender, family relationship, and social hierarchy.

In Biblical times, birth order and family affiliation supported claims, and it still does today.

Gender roles—claims based on what a man/boy or woman/girl should do.

People might justify their claims based on their family, ethnicity, employment, social/economic status, appearance, talents, or fame.

27. What is the always present base of claims? (53.3)

Superiority.

The individual may lay stress on the special significance of his time, his work, his plans, his always being right.

To be superior we must live in a world of constant comparisons. We must be smarter, thinner, more needy, more spiritual, more successful, prettier, richer etc. than others.

We think that our claims supersede those of others. We should be favored over others based on our rights, our worth, our connections, our race, our gender, etc. Our need to feel superior makes us demand partiality from others.

28. Does it help neurotics if we refuse to accede to their claims? (54.1)

No, not unless they have begun to assume responsibility for themselves.

Both refusing to accede and acceding to neurotic claims may make the claim more emphatic.

People felt entitled to Jesus' attention and were indignant when He wouldn't give them what they wanted. Perhaps He knew that acceding to their claims would not help them take responsibility for themselves.

29. Which of these or any other grounds for claims resonate with you? (53.1–55.3)

Open this question up to the group.

Examples: Strong feelings, love, justice, "I've done this for you and you should do this for me", piety, goodness, good intentions, injury from others, minority status, ". . . because I'm a Christian".

0:40/1:30 WI

30. Why is it important for neurotics to assert claims? (55.3)

Because they are crucial for the maintenance of a neurosis.

31. What can we expect if claims are frustrated? (55.4–56.1)

Intense reactions—there are undercurrents of fear, but the prevailing response is rage and anger, which has the character of righteous indignation.

Other reactions might be: withdrawing, hysteria, self-destructive behavior, tears, addictive behavior, passive-aggression, confusion, dismay, shock, sadness, anxiety. These reactions may all signal that a claim has been violated.

32. Hostility arises only if a frustration is, or is felt to be, what? (56.2)

Unfair.

As the Righteous Judge of All the Earth, I believe that I have the power to know that something is UNFAIR.

33. What results from this indignation that so drastically influences our judgment of others? (56.2)

Neurotic suspiciousness and quickly turning from a positive friendly attitude to one of total condemnation.

Claims are like landmines buried in the neurotic that explode in unforeseen ways when others violate them. Neurotics easily feel abused when their claims are not met.

Neurotics are not reliable or trustworthy. They can turn against you for completely irrational reasons.

34. What are the three courses neurotic anger takes? (56.3–57.1)

- A. **Suppressed**
- B. **Freely expressed**
- C. **Misery and self-pity**

35. It is easy to observe neurotic reactions in others, but what is in our real interest? (57.2)

To examine our own reactions.

We are not yet qualified or capable of examining the reactions of others. We are simply too neurotic and volatile.

Jesus gives us very valuable advice when He tells us to remove the beam in our own eye first. Every step toward self-awareness is progress.

36. What is not too difficult to recognize and discover? (57.2)

It is not too difficult to recognize an acute reaction to an individual frustration and discover the particular claim behind it.

This is one of the skills that we learn in the Karis Fellowships, to recognize the red flags of acute reactions and discover the claim it is signaling.

37. What are neurotics entirely incapable of tolerating? (58.1)

Adversities.

Adversity is anything that interferes with our search for glory or creates discomfort, obstruction, or a sense of insecurity.

38. What judgment makes adversity ten times harder? (58.2)

To consider adversity as UNFAIR.

39. What prevents neurotics from following valid advice? (59.1)

Their distorted vision – emotional blindness – which results from inner unconscious necessities.

Emotions and reactions become the measure of our reality.

Our vision is distorted by the power of emotion, and we cannot consider a logical or rational response.

Jesus was able to forgive because He understood this blindness: “Father forgive them for they literally know not what they do.”

40. What are the consequences of emotional blindness? (59.2)

A mixture of envy and insensibility toward others.

0:45/1:35 WI

41. What is another consequence of living by claims? (59.3)

A general feeling of uncertainty about rights.

As neurotics, we can be confused about our rights in a world of actuality—for example, our right to have real preferences, to ask for a raise or a job, to not be abused or attacked, to have healthy personal relationships, to be treated with respect, to have the rights that others enjoy in any given society, to have our own opinions, ideas, beliefs, and feelings.

Also, we are confused about rights regarding property, possessions, and resources.

42. What is perhaps the most frequent neurotic disturbance? (60.1)

Inertia.

The harboring of extensive claims contributes to inertia. Inertia is a paralysis of psychic energies. Psychic means all that involves intellectual processes, including the ability to be self-aware and envision possibilities.

Inertia is not a total lack of action. People with claims are still active; they just don't use their psychic energy for growth or change.

43. For what are claims a substitute? (60.1)

They are a substitute for actively working on our own problems.

In KF, we strongly encourage all members to work on themselves. If you are not working on yourself, it is because you have a claim that you do not have to work to gain the prize of freedom and connection with God and the support of the material and spiritual worlds.

We might claim that without making any effort, we should experience peace and the other qualities of the Fruit of the Spirit and automatically receive the promises of the Beatitudes. We think we should experience all these benefits even if we refuse to take up our cross and follow Jesus.

44. For neurotics, what should be enough to bring about any desired achievement? (60.1)

Mere intention.

- We may want, hope, or mean to do something, but then not do it. We unconsciously believe that our good intention should be enough to bring about a favorable outcome.
- The intention to do this book study will make me successful and healthy.
- I want to help my church, so I intend to write a check for \$10,000, but I never do. I believe that somehow my intention should be enough to support my church.

Statistically, only about one-third of this group will go on in their Karis training, and only one tenth will finish their training.

45. What unconscious belief do neurotics hold? (61.2)

To the magic of their will power nothing is impossible.

I will it, therefore I am. I imagine myself to be this person, therefore I am this person, and if I just put my mind to something, I can do it. If I cannot achieve what I put my mind to, the fault lies elsewhere.

46. What are all claims pervaded by? (62.1)

Expectations of magic.

- We believe that magically we will get away with our choices and our neglect.
- We will achieve great things without the necessary training, background or experience.
- I will just meet a wonderful spouse, already trained and compatible.
- I can make wonderful things happen if I have enough faith. (This is magic with a spiritual label.)

47. Claims are an indispensable means of what? (62.1)

Actualizing the idealized self.

48. For what are the claims a guaranty? (62.1)

Future glory.

The Bible continually encourages us to work on ourselves, our pride, and our fear so that God can work in our lives in ways that are beyond our imagination. In the wilderness, Satan tempted Jesus to gain instantly the glorious outcomes typically desired by each neurotic type without needing to do any hard work.

0:50/1:40 WI

49. As neurotics lose interest in their actual life, what happens? (62.2)

They become impoverished and neglect all that could make life worth living. The hope of their future possibilities becomes more and more the only thing that they live for.

Our energy is diverted from actual growth, learning skills, and preparing for the future and directed instead into more effectively asserting our claims.

50. What do neurotics feel they would lose if they became interested in themselves and their growth? (62.3)

Their title for future fulfillment.

- “If I stop chasing my tail, I’ll lose all the ground that I’ve gained.”
- “The idealized self that I’ve fought so hard for will become meaningless if I grow.”
- “If I work toward the True Self, I can’t hold on to the standards that support my dreams of glory.”

51. To what extent are neurotics capable of considering the way to health? (63.1)

To the extent that they become strong enough to dispense with the solution they found in self-idealization.

Nancy says: This is extremely difficult, but as I go forward, I realize that although it costs me to take up my cross and follow Jesus, it costs me a great deal more to keep up this crazy neurosis. It actually costs me my life.

If you are courageous enough to begin KF training, you will soon catch a glimpse of what surprising outcomes are possible. It might help to think of KF work as making a small, slow, steady investment in your future.

52. What is the overall function of claims? (63.2)

To perpetuate our illusions about ourselves and to shift responsibility to factors outside ourselves.

53. When we raise our “needs” to the dignity of claims, what are we doing? (63.2)

We are denying our own troubles and placing the responsibility for ourselves on other people, on circumstances, or on fate.

We continue to blame someone else for our dissatisfactions because if we were to stop blaming someone else, we would have to look at ourselves, and we must avoid that at all costs.

0:55 Students take a five-minute break. Break-out room (subgroup) facilitator returns to the main meeting (*3*) to report attendance and homework, then goes back to the subgroup and waits for the next facilitator to arrive before signing off.

1:45 WI subgroups return to main group by pressing *3*.

Lead Facilitator WI: “It is not possible to absorb all this material the first time around. Your ability to understand this material is not about intelligence or whether you are making enough effort. Your goal is simply to gain some familiarity with the material. Do what you can and give yourself credit for what you are able to do. The next two chapters are the longest in the course, so you might want to get started early on your reading guides.”

If time permits, here are some discussion questions:

- How is everyone feeling?
- Do you have any questions or comments?
- How might your approach to this material indicate your neurotic trend?

- Do you feel like you need to understand everything in this book?
- Do you feel overwhelmed, helpless, or hopeless?
- Do you feel bored and irritated by the limitations of the study or the group?
- What strategies did you find helpful when preparing your reading guides? Did you work on it all at once, find a certain place to work in, or perhaps work with someone else?

Lead Facilitator WI: "See you all tomorrow at 8:00 am CST."

Stop the recording. (*9 then 1) WI

All facilitators, please stay after the meeting to confirm student attendance and homework completion on the [NHG Attendance Spreadsheet](#).

Lead Facilitator: "Are there any comments or questions?"

¹ This reading guide refers to the 1991 edition of *Neurosis and Human Growth: The Struggle Toward Self-Realization* by Karen Horney, published by W.W. Norton and Company Inc. New York.

² Phil. 4:8-9.